

Tense

PEL125_ Week 1

Present Simple Tense

1. We use the present simple to describe things that are always true, or situations that exist now and, as far as we know, will go on indefinitely:

- It takes me five minutes to get to school.
- Trees grow more quickly in summer than in winter.
- Liz plays the violin brilliantly.



2. We use the present simple to talk about habits or things that happen on a regular basis:

- I leave work at 5.30 most days.
- Each July we go to Turkey for a holiday.

3. We often use the present simple with verbs that perform the action they describe:

- I admit I can't see as well as I used to. (= an admission)
- I refuse to believe that he didn't know the car was stolen. (= a refusal)

Other verbs like this (sometimes called performative verbs) include accept, acknowledge, advise, apologise, assume, deny, guarantee, hope, inform, predict, promise, recommend, suggest, suppose, warn.

4. We use the present simple to describe something that we regularly do at a particular time.

- We usually watch the news on TV at 9.00. (= we start watching at 9.00)

Present Continuous Tense

1. To talk about particular actions or events that have begun but have not ended at the time of speaking,

For e.g.

- The car isn't starting again.
- 'Who are you phoning?' 'I'm trying to get through to Joan.'
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We often use time expressions such as **at the moment, at present, currently, just, and still** to emphasise that the action or event is happening now:



2. When we describe repeated actions or events that are happening at or around the time of speaking, we use the present continuous:

- Why are you jumping up and down?
- I'm hearing a lot of good reports about your work these days.

3. We use the present continuous to imply that a situation is or may be temporary.

- We're usually watching the news on TV at 9.00. (= we're already watching at 9.00)
- Banks are lending more money (these days) to encourage businesses to expand, (implies a temporary arrangement)

Present Simple & Present Continuous

Present Simple



Present Continuous



S + verb

S + am/is/are (not) + V-ing

Express general truths

E.g: It rarely rains in the desert.

Describe actions happening now

E.g: She is reading a newspaper upstairs.

Indicate present habits

E.g: The birds return to the island every morning.

Express annoying habits (+ always)

E.g: You're always forgetting to pay the bills.

Express timetable events

E.g: The plane to London takes off at 6:30 a.m.

Describe future arrangements

E.g: She's getting married on 3 November.

Indicate permanent states

E.g: I like the new James Bond film.

Express temporary states

E.g: She's working at the museum until the end of this month.





We often prefer to use the present simple rather than the present continuous with verbs describing states:

- I really **enjoy** travelling.
- The group currently **consists of** five people, but we hope to get more members soon.

Common state verbs:

agree, assume, believe, belong to, contain, cost, disagree, feel, hate, have, hope, know, like, look, love, own, prefer, realise, regret, resemble, smell, taste etc.

We can use the present continuous with some **state verbs** when we want **to emphasise that a situation is temporary**, for a period of time around the present. Compare:

- I consider him to be extremely fortunate. (This is my view) and
- I'm considering taking early retirement. (This is something I'm thinking about now)

We use the present continuous when we talk about changes, developments, and trends:

- The growing number of visitors **is damaging** the footpaths.
- I'm **beginning** to realise how difficult it is to be a teacher.

While telling a story/joke, we often describe the **main events** using the present (or past) simple and longer, **background events** using the present (or past) continuous:

- She goes (or went) up to this man and looks (or looked) straight into his eyes. She's carrying (or was carrying) a bag full of shopping...

We use the present simple and present continuous in **commentaries (for example, on sports events) and in giving instructions:**

- King serves to the left hand court and Adams makes a wonderful return. She's **playing** magnificent tennis in this match...
- You **hold** the can in one hand. Right, you're **holding** it in one hand; now you **take** off the lid with the other.

Simple present Vs. Present continuous

Simple Present

Permanent – facts, routines, habits etc,
Neutral things which happen repeatedly and regularly,
Physical states such as qualities, appearances,
Mental states such as thoughts and desires

Present continuous

Actions happening at the time of speaking – temporary or unfinished,
How many times/how repeatedly/frequently an action happens,
The action is in a temporary or unfinished state at a particular time

Bring to life past events, make them appear more recent

Explain the plot of a story

To talk about a future event

Complete the sentences with appropriate verbs. Use the same verb for each sentence in the pair. Choose the present continuous if possible; if not, use the present simple. (A)

- 1 a It.....us a fortune at the moment to send our daughter to dance classes.
b It.....a fortune to fly first class to Japan.
- 2 a I.....sitting down at the end of a long day and reading a good book.
b It's a wonderful book. I.....every moment of it.
- 3 a We've always wanted a house in the country, but we.....on where it should be.
b When they agree with each other on so many important issues, I can't understand why they
.....now on this relatively minor matter.
- 4 a With growing concerns about the environment, people.....to use recycled paper
products.
b He doesn't like publicity, and.....to stay firmly in the background.
- 5 a 'Can I speak to Dorothy?' 'She.....a shower. Can I take a message?'
b My brother.....three children, all girls.
- 6 a Although he.....three cars, all of them are extremely old.
b In the north of the country, fewer and fewer people.....the houses they live in.

Uses of Present Perfect

1. Actions started in the past and continuing in the present

- They haven't lived here for years.
- She has worked in the bank for five years.
- Have you played the piano since you were a child?

2. When the time period referred to has not finished

- I have worked hard this week.
- It has rained a lot this year.
- We haven't seen her today.

Actions repeated in an unspecified period between the past and now.

- They have seen that film six times
- It has happened several times already.

Actions completed in the very recent past (+just)

- Have you just finished work?
- I have just eaten.



When the precise time of the action is not important or not known

- Someone has eaten my soup!
- Have you seen 'Gone with the Wind'?

We use the past tense to talk about:

1. something that happened once in the past:

- I met my wife in 1983.
- We went to Spain for our holidays.
- They got home very late last night.

2. something that happened several times in the past:

- When I was a boy, I walked a mile to school every day.
- We swam a lot while we were on holiday.
- They always enjoyed visiting their friends.



3. something that was true for some time in the past:

- I lived abroad for ten years.
- He enjoyed being a student.
- She played a lot of tennis when she was younger.

DIFFERENCES BETWEEN

PRESENT PERFECT TENSE

It is used to express unfinished events that started in the past and continue to the present.

I **have lived** in Paris for five years. (I still live in Paris)

It is used to express finished events in someone's life. (if the person is still alive - life experience)

He **has** never **travelled** by plane. (He is alive)

It is used to express finished events that happened in the past and the impact of the event is now continuing.

We can't reach Paul by phone. **Have** you **seen** him?

It is used to with unfinished time words (this week, today, this year etc.).

I **have eaten** lots of plumps **today**. (today is not over yet)

PRESENT PERFECT TENSE

It is used to express finished events.

My son **was** sick on Monday. (My son isn't sick now)

It is used to express finished events in someone's life. (if the person is dead)

He **travelled** a lot by plane. (He is dead)

It is used to express finished events. There is no result in the present.

He **went** to cinema two hours ago. (now he is at school)

It is used with finished time words (yesterday, last week, in 2000, etc.).

We **didn't** call him **yesterday**.

Choose a verb with either the present perfect or past simple for these sentences. (A & E)

agree appear continue disappear move reach show solve write

- 1 Research has shown that cycling can help patients overcome their illnesses.
- 2 The rabbit just.....in my garden one day last week.
- 3 With this promotion, I feel that I.....a turning point in my career.
- 4 Oh, no! My car.....!
- 5 Quite early in the negotiations, they.....to lower the prices.
- 6 In 1788 he.....his last great work in Vienna.
- 7 There's not much more to do, now that we.....the main problem.
- 8 Throughout the summer of 1980 Malcolm.....to divide his time between London and New York.
- 9 When he was 13, his parents.....to the United States.

- We use the present perfect when we talk about something that happened in a period of time up to the present.
e.g. Science **has made** many major advances **this century**,
- We use the past simple to talk about something that happened at a particular, finished time in the past.
e.g. Scientists **made** some fundamental discoveries **in the 18th century**

- We can use either the present perfect or the past simple to talk about repeated actions or events.
- To suggest that the **action or event might happen again**, we use the **present perfect**. **Example** : Timson has made 13 films and I think her latest is the best
- To suggest that it is **finished** and **won't happen again**, we use **simple past tense**

Example : Timson made 13 films before she was tragically killed in a car accident

We use the present perfect to talk about a state that existed in the past and still exists now.

- I **have known** him most of my working life. (I am still working)

We use the past simple if the state no longer exists.

- • I **knew** him when we were both working in Rome

In news reports, you will often read or hear events introduced with the present perfect, and then the past simple is used to give the details:

- The film star Jim Cooper **has died** of cancer. He **was** 68 and **lived** in Texas...



- The US space shuttle Atlantis **has returned** safely to earth. It **landed** in Florida this morning...

- 'A teacher from Oslo **has become** the first woman to cross the Antarctic alone. It **took** her 42 days to make the crossing with her dog team...'

Simple Past and Past Perfect

- We use the past simple rather than the past perfect when we simply talk about a single activity or event in the past:
- I handed the letter to him.
- We use the past perfect when we say what we wanted or hoped (etc.) to do, but didn't:
- e.g. : I **had wanted** to visit the gallery before I left Florence, but it's closed on Sundays.

- When we use a time expression (e.g. after, as soon as, before, by the time (that), when) to say that one event happened after another,
- we use **past perfect** for the event that happened **first** and the **past simple** for the event that **happened second**
- **E.g.** After Ivan (had) finished reading, he put out the light.

Past Perfect continuous and Past Perfect

- We use the **past perfect continuous** when we talk about the **continuity** or duration of a situation or activity, and the **past perfect** to talk about the **completion** of a situation or activity or its effects
- If we talk about **how long** something went on up to a particular past time, we use the **past perfect continuous**.

If we talk about **how many times** something happened in a period up to a particular past time, we use the **past perfect tense**.

PAST PERFECT VS. PAST PERFECT CONTINUOUS

PAST PERFECT



PAST CONTINUOUS

Had + Past Participle

- Express a past action, already finished when another past action happened

E.g. I met them after they had divorced each other.

- Emphasize the result of an activity in the past

E.g. I had been to London twice by the time I got a job in New York.

- Show two events in the past that are linked

E.g. I couldn't take my flight because I had forgotten my boarding pass.

Had been + V-ing

- Describe a past action which started in the past and continued to happen after another action or time in the past

E.g. Sara had been working here for two weeks when she had the accident.

- Emphasize the duration of an activity in the past

E.g. Richard needed a holiday because he had been working hard for six months.

- Show the cause of a past action

E.g. I had been travelling all night, so I was tired.





THANK YOU!